

Sample Lumbar Spine MRI Coverage Policy

Historical Restrictive Version for AI Version Comparison Demo

Document Type: Coverage Policy / Billing and Coding Policy

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Purpose

This historical demo policy reflects an older and more restrictive approach to lumbar spine MRI utilization management. It is intentionally designed to differ materially from the newer policy so comparison workflows can identify clinical, reimbursement, coding, and authorization changes.

Covered Service

Lumbar spine MRI may be considered for severe lumbar radiculopathy, suspected spinal stenosis with neurological compromise, post-surgical complication assessment, documented trauma, or confirmed malignancy workup. Routine use for uncomplicated low back pain is generally not covered.

Medical Necessity Criteria

- For uncomplicated low back pain, lumbar MRI is covered only after at least twelve weeks of conservative therapy.
- Conservative therapy must include supervised physical therapy and physician-directed medication management unless contraindicated.
- MRI before twelve weeks requires documented motor weakness, bowel or bladder dysfunction, suspected fracture, or known malignancy.
- Repeat lumbar MRI is covered only when surgery is being planned or when new neurological deficit is documented.

Prior Authorization

Prior authorization is required for all outpatient and freestanding imaging requests. Emergency department imaging without prior authorization requires retrospective documentation review.

Billing and Coding Requirements

Claims must include a valid CPT procedure code, supported ICD-10 diagnosis code, ordering provider information, prior authorization number, and documentation of completed conservative therapy. HCPCS contrast agent billing is not separately payable under this version.

Type	Code	Description	Coverage Note
CPT	72148	MRI lumbar spine without contrast	Covered when strict criteria are met
CPT	72149	MRI lumbar spine with contrast	Covered only for infection or malignancy evaluation
ICD-10	M54.16	Radiculopathy, lumbar region	Supported diagnosis
ICD-10	M48.061	Spinal stenosis, lumbar region	Supported diagnosis

Excluded Services

- Screening MRI for nonspecific low back pain without objective neurological findings is not covered.
- Repeat imaging within twenty-four months for the same indication is not covered unless surgery is planned.
- Contrast-enhanced MRI for uncomplicated radiculopathy is not covered.
- Experimental imaging protocols and out-of-network mobile MRI services are not covered.

Frequency Limit

One lumbar spine MRI is allowed per twenty-four-month period for the same clinical indication unless there is new trauma, confirmed malignancy, or planned surgical intervention.

Required Documentation

- History and physical examination with symptom duration and pain severity score.
- Provider attestation confirming failure of conservative therapy for at least twelve weeks.
- Physical therapy notes or equivalent supervised treatment documentation.
- Neurological examination findings for any request submitted before twelve weeks.
- Prior imaging report and operative planning note for repeat MRI requests.

Synthetic Contract Terms

For demonstration only, the allowed amount for CPT 72148 is \$620 when performed by an in-network freestanding imaging provider. Member cost share may include a \$75 copay and 30% coinsurance, subject to benefit plan design. Out-of-network lumbar spine MRI reimbursement is not eligible under this historical version except for documented emergency care.

Decision Examples

Scenario	Expected Policy Outcome	Reason
M54.16, CPT 72148, twelve weeks therapy, prior authorization present	Approve	Coverage and authorization criteria satisfied.
Low back pain, six weeks therapy, no red flags	Deny	Conservative therapy requirement not met.
Progressive neurological deficit, no prior authorization	Manual review	Urgent exception may apply, but retrospective review is required.

Regulatory and Audit Note

Coverage determinations should comply with applicable federal and state requirements, medical necessity review standards, audit documentation policies, and member benefit language. This synthetic historical policy contains no PHI and is intended only for software demonstration.